Early in my term, on my way back from office one evening, I asked the driver to stop in Colaba, got off the car and walked around for about half an hour just to get a feel of the place. The next morning, the protocol and security officer attached to the governor's office told me: 'Sir, next time you want to go anywhere on your way back home, let me know. I'll come along with you.' Evidently, the driver was under instruction to keep the security officer informed in real time about my movements, and he himself was uncomfortable with my gallivanting on my own.

In conversations with colleagues and acquaintances, whenever the topic came up, I would express my frustration at not being able to explore Mumbai on my own. But somehow, that reaction took on life as 'the governor doesn't like Mumbai'. Perhaps this is where 'being reconciled to living in Mumbai' came from.

This is hardly the place to go into the usual Delhi–Mumbai squabble. There are differences between the two, both subtle and striking, that I got to notice as I spent time in Mumbai. Delhi is the nation's capital and you can't miss the very essential political undertone in your everyday work life there. Its history and grandeur—especially the Raisina complex where my office was—are overpowering; its art and culture scene is lively. But Delhi is also guilty of an exaggerated air of self-importance and an all-pervading sense of self-righteousness.

Mumbai is different. The leafy streets and colonial buildings of South Mumbai add to its charm. The city oozes energy and vitality from every nook and corner. Mumbai is a city of stark contrasts—providing opportunities to millionaires to pursue their riches and millions of poor to pursue a livelihood. For many, Mumbai is a city where their dream begins; for many others, it marks the end of a dream.

Contrary to the perception conveyed by the reporter's question, I actually came to like Mumbai—the allure of the city grew on me. There are many things I recall with fondness and nostalgia—the Mumbai rains, walking along the Worli Seaface, eating in the hole-in-the-wall vegetarian Maharashtrian eateries in Tardeo, strolling in High Street Phoenix Mall, and watching plays in Prithvi Theatre.